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Q How do you view the adoption of open source technology in the Indian SME segment?

Open source technology is witnessing a good amount of adoption across the country. Some state governments and government organisations have officially adopted open source. We also come across a lot of reports stating that the government of India is also planning to adopt and promote open source software in most public software domains. This is good news, as open source technology is growing and flourishing in the desired way. Moreover, the non-profit and business sectors have shown great affinity to this technology, especially owing to the economic slowdown, which had called for urgent cost-cutting measures.

Q Which part of the country has been most responsive when it comes to open source technologies?

The world has welcomed open source technologies. India has accepted it. We see it everywhere, basically. Though we operate from Kerala in south India, we have already established a worldwide customer base and we have clients from most parts of India. Technology wise, we believe there is a greater response to open source technologies in the southern part of India, but other regions are not far behind in the race.

Q You have been working on open source technology solutions for a long time now. How have you seen the market evolve over these years?

Clients in the SME segment and educational sectors have shown tremendous interest in the adoption of open source technology, particularly in services like content management systems, e-business systems, learning support systems and other Web applications. Additionally, we have seen a huge shift in the Web hosting industry. Hosting companies have already started to forget the traditional servers, and are rapidly moving towards virtual private Linux servers and public cloud services because of the cost benefits. There has been an increased level of awareness about open source technologies, thanks to the media coverage and the government level adoption of open source. When such an adoption takes place, it continually throws up the requirement for a technology-oriented work force. This is exactly what we have been contributing to the industry.

When we first began our operations 15 years ago, we understood the importance of open source technologies in the long run, and aligned ourselves towards initiating our association with Red Hat Inc., as an authorised training partner back in 2003. We knew that when there is a technology shift to open source, most organisations would require a workforce that could easily manage and control this change with minimal costs. We have witnessed many organisations passing through the recession, the economic slowdown and the various industry hiccups over these years. But, when we look back today, it is evident that we have only supported the industry in a beneficial way by supplying trained talent. Today we cater to the requirements of clients from over 50 countries across the globe.

Q What are the main challenges that you face when it comes to convincing the SME segment about adopting solutions based on open source technology?

Educating clients is a challenge. To get SME companies educated about the cost advantages offered by adopting open source technology is not an easy task. It requires a lot of effort. Well, at the end, it is all fruitful, but the initial stages of convincing a client is a tough road to cross. Then again, there is a common misunderstanding that, if the source code is open, it is not secure. People believe that it is open to all and that there could be security holes and flaws, which could be utilised by hackers. While no software can be free of bugs or vulnerabilities, open source has the backing of the community members, who find out the vulnerabilities and patch them at a much faster pace than most of the closed source alternatives.

It is also difficult to convince clients about the cost of program code, customisation and service, because some people think that everything about open source is free. It is not that way. Basically, it boils down to the fact that the words ‘open’ and ‘free’ are not perceived by everyone in the real sense of open source.

Q Tell us about your product offerings and their development being done in India?

We focus on open source based services—implementation and training—typically as per client requirements. We specialise in setting up cloud based infrastructure and services, Web applications and mobile applications. We do this by customising existing open source applications or by building custom applications. This includes public and private cloud configurations, migration to the cloud, managed support for the cloud, application management and developer support in the cloud, cloud based development, content management systems, e-commerce systems, learning management solutions, custom Web portals, etc.